

The Two Opposing Faces of Brown's 'Liberal Learning' Model

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In the hyper-competitive landscape of present-day higher education, Brown University most distinguishes itself from other elite universities by its open curriculum, according to which students have no requirements placed on their learning besides a writing requirement and the requirements of their intended concentration. This open curriculum can be said to form one of two components of Brown's self-identity as an educational institution dedicated to what it calls 'liberal learning'. The other component is DIAP, or the diversity inclusion and action program, inaugurated in 2016 by President Christina Paxson, with the purpose of dealing with 'long standing issues concerning diversity and inclusion in the Brown curriculum and academic environment'¹. This component, rather than distinguishing Brown, brings it closer with other universities which have undertaken diversity programs in recent years. It is well known to most people at Brown that both of these components did not start on Brown's own initiative, but have their antecedents in a set of twin student movements that occurred at Brown in late 1968: the movement for curricular reform on the one hand, and the Black student walkout on the other. In its promotion of the open-curriculum and DIAP, Brown now claims these two legacies proudly, even though, as most of you may know, they caused the administration a considerable amount of consternation in their own day. But how exactly did two divergent but connected movements, which caused Brown such a headache in 1968, eventually become the sources by which it would come to define and distinguish itself as a liberal university?

Recently, a nascent interest in decolonizing the curriculum has begun amongst several students in the form of the student organization Decolonization@Brown (or D@B). Their diagnoses of the still-colonized nature of Brown's classes, not to mention entire departments, is accurate. Nonetheless, one wonders: what exactly does this organization hope to achieve? Are they attempting to get Brown to decolonize itself? This curious mixture on the part of D@B of a critique of Brown's institutions coupled with the hope that Brown could be reformed is not new. In fact, it was the core belief that tied both the curriculum reform movement and the Black Walkout in 1968, despite their divergent means and ends. What is more interesting is that present day initiatives, such as D@B, represent an attempt to reconcile the two parts of Brown's liberal identity. While D@B's program is ostensibly wider than the curriculum, focusing for instance on colonial status of monuments littered throughout the university, their curricular initiatives for the time being work within the existing programs for diversity and inclusion. What we hope to argue is that the reconciliation of the two sides of Brown's 'liberal learning' model is not easy, that in fact there is a tension that exists between these two faces: on the one hand, the presumption with the open curriculum that students can be the masters of their own educations, and on the other, efforts to make *all* students think about crucial questions related to race, power and privilege. The origins of this tension begin in 1968.

Though both the movement for curricular reform and the Black student walkout reached their apex at around the same time at the end of the fall semester of 1968, the ground for both had already been laid in the previous year, which in general was a tumultuous one for universities across America.

¹<https://www.brown.edu/about/administration/institutional-diversity/sites/oidi/files/Task%20Force-Diversity%20in%20Curriculum-September-2016.pdf>

The group of students who would go on to write the Report detailing the new curriculum, led by Ira Magaziner and Elliott Maxwell, had already been meeting as part of a Group Independent Study Project in the Spring and had commenced dialogue with the University and its then President, Heffner about the possibility for curricular reform. These students had also begun spreading their message to others in the university about their intended aims to reform education at Brown. The report that was compiled by these students espoused a liberal humanist philosophy of education based on student-centered learning. In their view, two key factors prevented students from attributing value to their 4 years of undergraduate education. Firstly, they were too preoccupied with the necessities of professional life that lay ahead of the university, which meant that they sacrificed opportunities to learn interesting subjects for those by which they could maximise career prospects. Secondly, even if they did choose subjects that they were passionate about, in the then distributional requirement system that existed, classes often focused on the teaching and retention of the facts of a discipline, and did not afford the opportunity to think one step behind, from a meta- level, about 'how the discipline allowed you to think' in a certain way. Their proposals to make education more student-centered, epistemologically inquisitive and comparative found resonance amongst many students and some professors, and later in Spring 1969, even President Heffner was willing to entertain them.

The men's Afro-American Society (AAS) at Brown had, since the Spring of 1967, been focused on one key issue: increased representation. Where the curricular reform movement had focused on the pressures of future professionalisation impinging on the education of students at Brown, the AAS, and later more acutely the Black women at Pembroke, brought attention to the fact that implicitly, Brown had assumed students acculturation to certain ideals even before they came into Brown, and those who had started coming *into* Brown from completely different world's than their traditional white demographic were seen as anomalies that needed to fall back on their own two feet. Thus, the demands presented to President Heffner by the Afro-American Society (AAS) on May 16th, 1968 had given him "a sense of real urgency" in addressing the grievances of Brown's Black students. But what is interesting is, with talk of curricular reform becoming increasingly popular, the chief means by which the university dealt with the AAS' demands was to introduce courses in African American studies. To 'institutionalise campus interest in Negro problems', the university introduced at the opening of the Fall semester courses in nineteenth and twentieth century black history, as well as courses on black literature in america². The university thought it had solved their demands, even as it ignored the thorny problem of representation. A response to them came when Black students of Brown and Pembroke walked out at the end of that semester. And while the increasingly popular curricular reform movement played a role in helping spread the word about the Black Walkout, Black students, particularly those at Pembroke, were careful to explain to their fellow students why their reasons for walking out were different from the demands of the curricular reform movement. Amongst the many contentious demands that were granted, the most important was the university's commitment to bettering representation of African-American students, even though it never could agree with Black Students demand for an 11% minimum. Additional measures to come out of the walkout included a board consisting of students for the recruitment of Black students for admissions, improved counselling services, and the creation of an Afro-American studies department.

² 'Brown '68-'69: The Year of the Black?', *The Brown Daily Herald*, September 1968

But what is interesting is that as a byproduct of a larger movement focused on representation, the Afro-American studies department was coming into existence at the exact same time when the open curriculum movement would radically individualise learning. As a result, while it would become an institutionalised space for the study and teaching of African American history and literature or other subjects, it would exist alongside courses that could teach American literature without mentioning seminal Black writers. All those who took Afro-American studies classes from now on, therefore, would only do so because they decided it would add value to their individual education.

The story of Ido Jamar, a Pembroke student who would become the de-facto leader of the walkout, makes this tension clearer. Having come from a Virginia public high school that was the first in her district to be integrated, Jamar had come first in her school in Math, and had come to Brown intending to study the same. She was politically conscious, citing Frantz Fanon and Malcolm X as key influences. At Pembroke, she had found herself one of six black students in her whole class. She experienced a sense of social alienation like other black friends of hers, as exemplified once when her white friends pretended not to recognise her in the company of their parents. Her counsellor had deemed her unfit for the pure math track, and advised her to study applied math instead. Jamar also expressed her desire to study James Baldwin and Langston Hughes, and the history of slavery, not as African American authors or events, but as writers and moments that defined America. Now while Jamar was for all intents and purposes not opposed to the Universities efforts to institutionalise interest in Black history and literature, she did recognise that curricular reform, due to its popularity, had become a way to ignore underlying problems with insufficient representation and inadequate resources. And the Afro-American studies department that formed from the walkout, would initially at least, be unable to affect the general pattern of education in the way that the open curriculum had. Rather, it found itself, like all departments, provincialised within the university system, having to advertise interest in courses in Afro-American studies to those students willing to take it³.

When Paget Henry started teaching a course in Afro-Caribbean philosophy in the 1990s, it would take approximately 20 years before professors in the Philosophy department would recognise his course as a philosophy course in its own right. Now, when students are trying to, on a wider scale, think about the shared colonial legacies that cut across departments, the individualisation of the open curriculum and the provincialisation of departments has rendered that task quite difficult. If the open curriculum sought to radically individualise learning, maybe in 2020, when learning is so isolated and the university has expanded its reach into the privacy of people's rooms, we should attempt the opposite move, to figure out ways to make learning more communally meaningful, while still preserving the open curriculum's spirit of individual inquiry.

A Proposal for Curricular Reform

We propose a practical program that can be effectively implemented at Brown according to our historical framing. 2020 marks 4 years since the initial DIAP report in 2016, a list of suggestions formulated by a temporary committee of students, faculty and administrators that dealt with long standing issues

³ <https://www.brown.edu/initiatives/pembroke-oral-histories/interview/ido-jamar-class-1969>

concerning diversity and inclusion in the Brown curriculum and academic environment. The last suggestion that came out of the report was to reconvene the committee in 3 years to assess the implementation and effectiveness of the report's suggestions. The committee has been reconvened and is to be active from Fall 2020 to Spring 2021. The suggestions given in the 2016 report can be summarized as follows:

- Create several large introductory survey courses (preferably team-taught) addressing issues of racial, economic, social, and cultural inequity in the United States and globally.
- Encourage all concentrations to provide meaningful engagement with issues of diversity and inclusion.
- Continue support for both First-Year and Sophomore Seminars that focus on power, privilege, and social justice, and assessment of both programs.
- Pending review and approval by the College Curriculum Council, replace “Diverse Perspectives in Liberal Learning” with a new curricular designation, “Race, Power, and Privilege” (RPP); develop a more robust review process within the College Curriculum Council.
- Enhance support and resources for instructors and teaching assistants on inclusive teaching strategies.
- Increase support for the Engaged Scholars Program.
- Reconvene a committee in three years to evaluate the progress made on the recommendations in this report.⁴

From these suggestions some were effectively met. The most significantly unrealized is the first of the seven: the creation of large survey courses on topics concerning diversity and inclusion for the general student population. All departments but not all concentrations have been pushed to routinely update their diversity and inclusion action plans, which include reports where issues concerning diversity and inclusion are addressed at the departmental level. First-year and Sophomore seminars have increased in quantity, and some have been created under the DIAP label. That said, many concentrations in STEM lack a meaningful and rigorous approach to these issues although they might be engaging with these resources. The “DPLL” curricular designation was not substituted by “Race, Power, and Privilege” (RPP), but rather by DIAP. The review process conducted at the CCC to accept requests to use DIAP designation is taken seriously, but the requirements remain rather flexible and the number of applications heavily depend on faculty enthusiasm rather than administrative incentive. Impressive support has been generated for faculty and instructors concerning inclusive teaching strategies, notably championed by the Swearer Center. The engaged scholars program has considerably grown in size and has even recently been approved as a certifiable program at Brown. Lastly, the committee has been reconvened after 4 years rather than 3, currently evaluating the successes and the unfulfilled items of the 2016 report.

In 2016, at the same time the committee was active, two students from the Africana department realized a capstone project that offered recommendations based on research done regarding representative

⁴ Taken from:

<https://www.brown.edu/about/administration/institutional-diversity/sites/oidi/files/Task%20Force-Diversity%20in%20Curriculum-September-2016.pdf>

concentrations that suffered from issues relating to Diversity and Inclusion. The Critical Curriculum project (the capstone's title) investigated the state of the Biology, Computer Science, Economics, Literary Arts, and Physics concentrations by interviewing both students and faculty about issues relating to DIAP. Based on the data collected they offered critical suggestions and practical solutions to notable issues in these concentrations.

Following in the footsteps of the Critical curricular project, we would like to present in this report our own set of suggestions based on both student conducted investigation and reflections on the history of 'Liberal Learning' from 1968 to 2020 and the outcomes of the 2016 DIAP report. Decolonization at Brown (D@B), a student organization focused on decolonizing both the institution and curriculum of Brown university through student efforts and activism has formed a special task-force focused on the effectiveness of DIAP. This task-force has been regularly meeting since last August to organize meetings with professors and attend DIAP related events since their formation. They have collected faculty and student insight on DIAP matters as well as developed their own list of demands concerning Diversity and Inclusion at both the institutional and curricular level. We have been collaborating with the student members of this task-force as well as the current official working-group assigned by the College Curricular Council to deal with the revision of the 2016 DIAP report. Although the D@B task-force has done extensive work for DIAP matters at the institutional and administrative level, we will primarily focus on the curricular side of things. We are interested in how the Open Curriculum has both historically and presently contributed or acted against a curriculum with diverse intellectual perspectives that foment inclusion in the classroom and academia at Brown. After having narrated a historical account of the interaction between the open curriculum and struggles concerning racial injustice and representational disparity at both the level of personnel and curriculum, we will now focus on the present situation and the practical steps we can take as administrators, faculty, general staff and students to develop an effective diversity and inclusion action plan.

A DIAP Requirement

At the level of curriculum, DIAP is known through two forms: the DIAP course designation and the concentration DIAP report. The first of these is a label faculty can apply to their courses if they meet a set of focus areas in their course syllabus. These are the following:

- the ways different forms of power and privilege construct racial and identity formations in the U.S. and/or globally; the cultural, political, and intellectual responses to this racialization;
- the production of categories of ethnicity, race, gender, sexual orientation, class, religion, ability, citizenship status, and geography (and their intersections);
- the structures, institutions, practices, and attitudes that enable, maintain, or mitigate domestic and/or global disparities in health, income, education outcomes, media representations, etc.;

- the production of knowledge and difference in the context of discourses on race, power, and privilege.⁵

Faculty must explicitly deal with one of these points in their course. Then the CCC, the dean of diversity and inclusion and experienced faculty with DIAP courses revise and accept the designation. The second of these forms is a report each concentration is obliged to perform and update on a regular basis, which describes the way the concentration is complying with the institutional standards of Diversity and Inclusion.

The designation assures a way in which motivated faculty can expand the course offerings that would reflect an effective DIAP, and the departmental reports assure faculty commitment, recognizing that there are ways outside course offerings in which a department or concentration can abide by the values of the DIAP. That said, these two components can be used to separate compliance with DIAP values between departmental culture and curricular content and offerings. This can be exploited especially in fields where reflecting upon its history and being auto-critical of its methodologies is not classically part of their disciplinary narrative and practice. This is especially exemplified in STEM fields where course content is thought to be separate from the context of the discipline's development and the material origins of theories and ideas being taught in the classroom.

We recognize that the 1st and 2nd suggestions in the 2016 report would be highly beneficial for the advancements of the DIAP goals at Brown. That said, we would like to suggest some modifications to these two points for the 2020-2021 revision of 2016's report. First off, it seems like in the last 4 years the creation of the type of course outlined in suggestion 1 has proven to be difficult under the current deployment of DIAP in the curriculum. The departmental structure at Brown mandates that any course offered must be hosted by an existing department. Currently, departments with the capacity to teach "large introductory survey courses addressing issues of racial, economic, social, and cultural inequity in the United States and globally" are small departments like, notably, Africana Studies or Ethnic Studies, who have faculty committed to such an endeavour, but who, as it stands, would be overcommitting their time and overextending their responsibilities to their departments if they were to take on the institutional/curricular necessities outlined in the DIAP for the whole University. Even if we expand the

⁵ Taken from: <https://www.brown.edu/academics/college/degree/DIAPcourses>

scope to include other motivated and active departments who have made good use of the DIAP course designation like American Studies, Sociology, History, etc. the issue of diversity and inclusion should be addressed at a systemic, institution wide level. Fields of study that already implement the chore of educating about “issues of racial, economic, social, and cultural inequity” will continue to do so, and fields that believe they don’t share this responsibility will continue to increasingly rely on these departments for the accomplishment of the goals published in the DIAP that is supposed to encompass the entire university community.

It is also important to note that many of the fields who neglect responsibility of tackling DIAP issues at the curricular level because the knowledge they teach is self-evidently “neutral,” are actually some of the very fields that have been historically key in propagating racial, economic, social, and cultural inequity and disparity through its theories and “objective” knowledge that normally benefit those already in power. There are already courses and even concentrations at Brown dedicated to asking these questions and analyzing this phenomenon like courses in the English department dealing with Post-Colonial theory or the Science and Technology Studies concentration dealing with these issues in the case of STEM fields. Some students, thanks to the structure of the open curriculum, end up taking some of these courses, which as of now, might or might not be labeled as DIAP courses. But the flexibility of the open curriculum can be a double edge sword in this case, since many students, especially those in the STEM concentrations never experience any kind of auto-critique upon the fields they are beginning to practice.

Because every department must be involved and share the responsibility of the institutional DIAP goals and every student should engage with these issues at the curricular and concentration level, we suggest that DIAP courses should become a departmental requirement for all concentrations. Just like writing is enforced as a universal skill necessary to succeed as an academic, a professional, or a scientist, as exemplified by the university wide requirement, today it is necessary for everyone to grapple with issues concerning racial, economic, social, and cultural inequity, and how any and every academic, professional or scientific endeavour interacts with these issues. We suggest a departmental requirement rather than a university wide requirement like the writing requirement, because of the concern raised about the unfair distribution of responsibility to those departments who are already doing an exemplary job at tackling these issues in their own fields or as a field of study in their own right. We believe that each department should require all concentrations it hosts to include a component that motivates and pushes students to grapple with these important issues and how their discipline is imbricated in these issues, not just offer

optional courses on topics that can be designated as DIAP. As we have seen, this last approach has not been effective across the entire university community for the past 4 years.

We acknowledge that not all departments have faculty prepared for such an endeavour. This is an important fact to consider when designing the structure of a department specific DIAP requirement for all concentrations. Because of this we have considered several existing innovative curricular models that already exist at Brown and some administrative strategies to remedy this issue.

Co-teaching has been increasing in popularity at Brown. Popular large lecture courses that serve as introductions to a discipline have often taken this approach like in the case of Introduction to Neuroscience or Equilibrium, Rate and Structure in Chemistry. In these courses, having a team of faculty members representing different teaching styles, expertises in the field, and perspectives/opinions on the subject matter, can be extremely valuable at the introductory course level. In small upper level and graduate level seminars, the team teaching approach is also represented in the humanities by many of the seminars offered by the Cogut Institute. In these seminars, faculty from different areas in the humanities pair up to co-teach on a topic of mutual interest, offering distinct perspectives that can be very fruitful when put together and contrasted. Co-teaching across departments can be a viable and valuable way of implementing required DIAP courses across concentrations that assure relevancy to the department's disciplinary practices and rigor concerning disciplinary critique and relevancy to DIAP. Co-teaching Science and Technology Studies faculty with a select cohort of faculty from the life sciences or physical sciences could make for a great course on the history and critique of scientific practices as the student also learns these practices. Requiring a course of this kind would forge future scientists, mathematicians and engineers that are also critical and conscious of their field's limitations and historical imbrication on development of the world as we know it (with a special emphasis on issues concerning DIAP).

Guest lecturing is another way in which faculty can introduce diverse perspectives in the classroom. An introduction to political science course could have a political theorist from the Africana department give a guest lecture, or a faculty member from Ethnic Studies could give a guest lecture for an intro class in international and public affairs. Although we again run the risk of putting the responsibility of DIAP complacency of other departments on the faculty that already engage with these topics, systematic interdisciplinary guest lecturing can be a potential way of having the experts collaborate with faculty

across departments and exponentially expose students to the active issues the DIAP engages through an expert lens within their own concentrations.

Lastly, hiring students to help with the development and realization of DIAP modules for introductory courses or higher level lecture courses and seminars is a successful model that can be replicated across different departments. In the computer science department this takes the shape of Ethics Teaching Assistants and Social Responsible Computing components for many of the homework assignments in the intro sequence courses. Many students at Brown are motivated by the same values represented in the DIAP. Creating space and remuneration for the development and implementation of DIAP components in well established courses that serve big portions of the student body by students is another way in which the university can begin to achieve the curricular goals of DIAP through a collaborative learning, research and teaching experience.

To conclude, the role of the university administrative body here is that of a facilitator. The creation of stimulus funds for these different suggestions could cut out pathways for faculty members and students to follow and materially validate many individuals and even departments who are already doing this work. Stimulus funds, grants or even fellowships should be created for the development of co-taught courses, the inclusion of interdisciplinary guest lecturers or the development of DIAP-related modules and DIAP-related TA positions across departments and concentrations. Although Brown's open curriculum celebrates the creativity and originality of students who challenge prescriptive academic pathways and decide to forge their own road, the truth of the matter is that many students end up relying on the small mosaic of structure necessary for an open curriculum in order to forge their original paths. A DIAP requirement of the type fleshed out above would introduce a missing structural component to the Brown curriculum that students can hang onto as they create their own way, and propagate its values beyond Brown. The Brown community, be it administration, staff, faculty or students, have a responsibility to see this process through and assist in the necessary transformation to the open curriculum so it does not remain closed under the history and intellectual practices of a small subset of the world.